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India's Immortal Comic Books: Gods, Kings, and Other Heroes

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Conclusion: The Global Legacy of *Amar Chitra Katha*

> We used to drive to the temple for holidays and other special occasions. It was an hour away, and sometimes I didn't want to go. I'd rather stay home and play games with my friends outside, or play video games, you know. But my parents bribed me: If I went and was good, they would give me a comic book to read on the way back. I guess as a kid I didn't really understand why we worshipped those gods in the temple, what they meant. But I remember reading the *Hanuman* comic in the car one time and finding a connection with Hinduism. Hanuman is like the Indian version of Superman. He has these special powers, and he tries to do good with them.
>
> *A reader*

In 1990, the producers of *Amar Chitra Katha* released two new issues that radically differed from their successful comic book formula: *An Exciting Find* (no. 430) and *Indus Valley Adventure* (no. 432). In these issues our "heroes" are Vijay and Durga, a boy and girl who go on holiday with their grandfather, an amateur archaeologist, to Harappa, the ancient city of ruins in the northwestern region of the Indian subcontinent. They are completely bored with their grandfather's history lesson until they uncover a time machine that takes them back to the year 2000 BCE, when the Indus Valley civilization thrived. There they learn all about this ancient civilization by walking through its markets, playing with the local children, and attending a public sacrificial ritual before returning to their own time. Author Yagya Sharma described these comics, which he had envisioned as the first in a larger sequence of themed issues, as among his best scripts:

> I said, let's try using the common people as the central figures. Then we could write history from a completely different perspective. I thought we could look at the period from Harappa up to Akbar. Stopping at Akbar, because he was the last glorious king in India. And starting with Harappa because at that time there was a lot of new information coming out about that civilization. Lots of research was needed, a different kind of research, to write from this perspective. So we began with the *Indus Valley Adventure*.[1] We planned two or three others on the Indus Valley, with these same characters, and then we were going to move on to the Vedic period. But I had to leave. I could not make enough of a living just writing the comic book scripts. So I took another position. Possibly they couldn't find the right author to write these scripts. It takes a lot of imagination to create new characters out of nothing and to tell the story from this sort of perspective. It is an unusual perspective. Perhaps the perspective was just too unusual. Perhaps it didn't appeal.

Artist Yusuf Bangalorewala illustrated *An Exciting Find*, and he also described it as the best work he had done for the *ACK* series:

> My best work for *Amar Chitra Katha* from a technical point of view was *An Exciting Find*, an adventure of a twin brother and sister duo who are transported back 4,500 years [*sic*] right into the Indus Valley or Harappan civilization. Did Anant Pai show you this book? They published just a few copies that were available for around six months. After that there were no reprints. Maybe it failed to sell owing to an ugly cover. But in my opinion the inside stuff made it the most well illustrated, adventurous, exciting, and thrilling book for Indian children during that period. It was done with a Rotring pen with a full ink reservoir to last two or three pages, unlike *Mirabai* or *Tansen*, which were done with a bare crow quill nib dipped every twenty seconds into an ink pot! I did this classy book just before I did *Jawaharlal Nehru*, around 1988 or 1989.

The author and the artist of these issues both stress the originality of the story line and the artwork. Yet *An Exciting Find* and *Indus Valley Adventure* did not sell well. Anant Pai agreed with Sharma that the perspective was just too unusual for *ACK*'s readers: "We received a few positive letters. But we received many more letters of complaint, requesting that we bring back the old heroes." Thus the other scripts that had originally been envisioned as part of this sequence were abandoned.

Most *ACK* readers were simply not interested in reading about time machines or other fictionalized novelties, nor were they interested in reading about "common people." Instead, they wanted to read about their Indian heritage, to envision it, to believe in it, to take comfort in it. They wanted formulaic heroes like the mythological god-king Rama, the historical warrior-king Shivaji, and the modern freedom fighter Bhagat Singh: heroes who battled their foes and either emerged victorious or else died bravely in the process. For the readers of these comics, this is the very formula for Indianness. And this is true not only of the Indians who read these comic books in India but also of the transnational Indians who read these comic books throughout the world today.

The *Amar Chitra Katha* series seemed to be dying out in the early 1990s. Sales of *Jawaharlal Nehru* (no. 436, 1991), about India's first prime minister, another issue that broke with the successful formula in its overly biographical and academic tone, were very disappointing: only 24,000 copies sold, nowhere near the break-even mark of 40,000 copies (Doctor 1997, 38). Anant Pai and the other *ACK* producers decided that it was time to pull the plug and stop creating new issues. If *ACK* has weathered this storm and even made a comeback in recent years—creating new issues, reprinting bestsellers, and moving into new media like television, animation, and the internet—this resurgence is due largely to its ever-broadening base of global Indian readers. The reader quoted above is a former student of mine who grew up in the United States, born to parents who had emigrated from northern India. He too finds the *ACK* formula appealing in its lineup of formulaic mythological and historical Indian superheroes who try "to do good," like the Hindu monkey-god Hanuman, who fights the evil demon-king Ravana by Rama's side in the *Rāmāyaṇa* epic. But his statement also alludes to the significance of this series for Indians, and especially Hindus, who now live outside of India.

The Pleasures of Reading Comic Books in the Indian Diaspora

As discussed in the introduction, there are many interrelated and often overlapping pleasures associated with reading *ACK* comic books in India: the pride entailed in reading indigenous comics featuring uniquely Indian heroes and stories; the patriotism that is inspired by reading comics about India's brave historical heroes; the lighthearted humor that is encountered in some issues; the pleasure of the comic book medium itself in its short and colorful format; the comfort taken from the formulaic pattern of storytelling; and the pleasure that Hindus specifically take in learning more about their religion through the mythological comics. Understanding these pleasures is key to understanding why these comic books have come to occupy such a cherished place in the lives of so many of their readers in India. For transnational or nonresident Indians (NRIs) who have emigrated from India to other countries and those born to émigré parents, these comic books are associated with two other pleasures that are unique to those readers in the Indian diaspora: first, the pleasure of maintaining a connection with the Indian "homeland" by reading about its historical eras and leaders; and second—for Hindus in particular—the pleasure of learning to articulate what Hindus believe in an environment where Hinduism is not the majority religion and where a perceived vacuum of resources about Hinduism is often keenly felt. One NRI whose parents immigrated to Canada from the state of Uttar Pradesh in northern India summarized this succinctly in his statement about what these comics meant to him:

> I was born and raised in Edmonton, Canada. Both of my parents are from the U.P. (Faizabad and Gonda). As we did not have any relatives here when I was growing up, I relied almost exclusively on *ACK* for learning about Hinduism and the history of India.

Like my methods for studying the consumption of *ACK* in India, my methods for studying the consumption of these comics beyond India were also wide-ranging. I have had many conversations with students of Indian heritage in the United States; I spent a month in 2002 in Great Britain speaking with NRIs there about the comics; I have visited Hindu temples and Indian community centers in the United States to learn about their youth education programs and their usage of *ACK* comics in such programs and in their libraries; and I have spoken with Indian grocery store owners in the United States who stock these comics on their shelves in addition to imported Indian grocery items, household products, and films. Once again, while all of this helped to form a picture of what these comics mean to their NRI readers, much of my insight into the significance of *ACK* for readers in the diaspora comes from those who sought me out after learning about my research. After *India Abroad* articles on my research were published (Joshi 2003; Saptharishi 2007), many readers in North

America contacted me to express their love for these comics, and some even generously offered to share their comic book collections:

> I am in Austin, and one of my friends in Virginia read about you in *India Abroad* newspaper, about your research project. They have lot of books of *Amar Chitra Katha* cartoon storybooks similar to Aesop Fables and want to send you if you need them and can use them.

In addition to North American NRIs, Indians living around the globe have contacted me—from Australia to Brazil to Kuwait to London to Singapore to Tanzania—demonstrating just how widespread the readership of *ACK* is. They stress that they have often had to explain facets of Indian culture to others in their community who are not familiar with it and who may even have absorbed negative stereotypes about India and Indians. The *ACK* comic books, with their many issues on ancient, medieval, and modern Indian heroes, helped them to develop a sense of pride about Indian history and civilization and thus about their own Indian heritage. Certainly this was the case for one reader of Indian heritage in Brazil, who mentioned that he buys the comics to share with his Brazilian girlfriend as a way of countering common misperceptions about India:

> *ACK* conveys to her a different India from what many Christian missionaries in Latin America paint: full of poverty, hunger, superstition, and ignorance. While I understand that *ACK* is a distorted version of reality, it is needed to balance the worldview created by missionary education in the western world. . . . My European and Latin American friends have been amazed at a nonacademic comic book that is so interesting and engaging that children actually read it.

The vast majority of NRI readers who contacted me were Hindus who explained that the comic books also helped them to better understand what it means to be a Hindu and to articulate what Hindus believe and why. To understand this point, it is useful to take a closer look at the American diaspora community—the Indian diaspora with which my research has been most involved—as an example. The immigration of Hindus and other religious groups from India to the United States occurred in two phases. The first phase consisted of the early immigrants who came from the northwestern part of the Indian subcontinent (the Punjab region) to California and other areas along the West Coast that were in need of agricultural laborers. This migration took place from the mid-nineteenth century until new U.S. immigration laws were passed in 1917 and 1924 that discriminated against Asians (including Indians). The second phase consisted of the new immigrants who began to arrive after the passage of the 1965 Immigration and Naturalization Act, which reversed the previous immigration laws and initiated preferential admission of Asians who were considered highly skilled. Karen Isaksen Leonard has shown that whereas the first phase of

South Asian immigrants to America "acted essentially on their own, either carrying out private religious acts or discarding their religions," the second phase of immigrants was very different in that they sought to retain their religious identities and establish visible and permanent places for Hinduism and other South Asian religions in their new homeland by founding religious organizations, building Hindu temples and community centers, and importing religious specialists and ritual items (1997, 107). These Indian immigrants were typically well educated professionals who came to America to pursue advanced educational opportunities and professional employment. Furthermore, most of these immigrants initially planned to return to India. However, as time passed and these immigrants married and had children, they began to settle down. They bought homes, enrolled their children in schools, applied for permanent residency, and built Indian community centers and Hindu temples.

Several recent studies of Hinduism in America have discussed the rise of a Hindu temple tradition beginning in the 1970s. The Sri Lakshmi Temple in Ashland, Massachusetts, celebrated its grand opening in 1986 and its formal consecration in 1990, but plans for this temple began in 1978 when a group of Hindu immigrants living in New England decided they were in need of a permanent religious edifice in their new homeland. Discussing this process, Diana Eck writes:

> In the 1970s new Indian immigrants to Boston, most of them professionals who had come during their student years, took jobs and settled in New England. They all intended to return to India eventually. Then they began to have children, and before long their children were in grade school. By now, these young families were putting down deeper roots in America and beginning to look toward a future here. They realized that their children would have no cultural or religious identity as Hindus at all unless they themselves began to do something about it. . . . These Hindus were engineers and doctors, metallurgists and biochemists, not temple builders. In fact, many of them had not been actively religious at all in India. Had they returned to Madras or Bangalore, they would never have become involved in the building or administration of a temple. But here in America their education as Hindus took on a new and practical form. (2002, 88–89)

The earliest full-scale Hindu temples built in America (as distinguished from converted warehouses, churches, or other preexisting spaces) were dedicated in the 1970s, such as the Sri Maha Vallabha Ganapati Devasthanam Temple in the Flushing neighborhood of Queens in New York City and the Sri Venkateswara Temple in Penn Hills, Pennsylvania. In the decades since then, middle-class professionals have built Hindu temples in urban areas across the United States (see Waghorne 2004; Dempsey 2006). The communities behind all of these temples share the concern that without such formal spaces for practicing Hinduism, their children would grow up denuded of their religious heritage. In India, without ever

going to the temple, a child could absorb many of the beliefs and practices of Hinduism through annual festivals, life-cycle ceremonies performed within the home, and the telling of mythological stories in various media. But in the American context, few such opportunities existed to learn about Hinduism outside of the temple. Additionally, parents who had not received any formal religious training often found themselves at a loss when called upon to explain Hindu beliefs or practices to their children or to non-Hindu neighbors and co-workers, and so they desired a formal establishment that would aid them in articulating their religious beliefs and educating their children. Discussing this sentiment in the context of her conversations with Hindus at the Sri Venkateswara Temple in Penn Hills, Vasudha Narayanan writes:

> It is always difficult to perceive oneself clearly and to articulate one's faith and tradition to oneself, the community and to one's children, especially if one has had no formal training or education in the field. But such is the predicament of a Hindu here; having grown up in India, soaking up the Hindu religious experience, does not make one a specialist in it. And yet, we are forced to articulate over and over again what it means to be a Hindu and an Indian to our friends and to our children, and one feels ill-equipped for the task. Frequently, all that one remembers of a festival in India is the food that was prepared for it; one was never called upon to explain Deepavali or Sankaranti, and least of all, "Hinduism." (1992, 172)

The significance of the *Amar Chitra Katha* comics for Hindus living in the American diaspora should be understood in this context. These comic books first began to be produced in 1967, just as the second phase of immigration to America had begun. As more and more titles were released throughout the 1970s, and as these immigrants started their own families, they found in these comics a handy tool with which to educate their children and themselves about Hindu mythology and Indian history. Thus whereas many readers of these comics in India already know the story being told before they read the comic, and therefore take pleasure in seeing that story retold in the comic book medium, readers in the diaspora have a very different experience, for they take pleasure not only in the medium itself but also in learning a new story of a new Indian hero. Many families reported that when they made visits to India over winter or summer holidays they would buy a set of all of the available comics to take back to America with them; other families reported that grandparents or aunts and uncles still living in India would ship the comics to their grandchildren or their nieces and nephews on birthdays and on festival occasions. In a format that was relatively cheap to purchase and transport overseas and that was concise, accessible, and interesting to children, these comics introduced the Hindu pantheon, explained Hindu mythology, and provided an overview of Indian history through its legendary leaders.

Those Hindus who were born in America to Indian émigrés or came to America as children repeatedly stressed that these comics were tremendously influential in teaching them Hinduism; in the words of one reader, it was from the *ACK* comics that he learned "all the values of Hinduism—Hindu *devas* [gods], *dharma* [religious and social duty], morality, family values, roles of men and women, and the glory of ancient Indian culture." Similarly, a young man of Indian heritage living in Texas stated, "I didn't really buy into worship like most devout Hindus, though I didn't want to offend my parents trying to be different either. I'd strongly think my moral yardsticks can be attributed to comics like *ACK* instead of those visits to the temple or religious instruction."

Many of these children were disinterested in temple visits, often because they felt self-conscious about seeming different from other children in their neighborhoods and schools. Frequently, they didn't know how to explain to themselves or to their non-Hindu friends why Hindus went to worship "those gods in the temple and what they meant." For the reader quoted at the outset of this chapter, Hindu beliefs and practices only began to make sense when he read the *Hanuman* (no. 19, 1971) comic book. Suddenly he knew the mythological stories associated with one of the gods that was featured in the temple his family visited, and he knew why Hanuman was worshipped. Whereas he had previously thought it was silly, even somewhat embarrassing, that Hindus worshipped animals, he volunteered the next year to play the role of Hanuman when his temple reenacted the *Rāmāyaṇa* epic, and as an adult he remains a devotee of this monkey-god.

In the American context, *ACK* comic books have been part and parcel of the Hindu temple experience. With the mission of educating the community about their Hindu faith and their Indian heritage, American Hindu temples were built not only as places of worship but also as community centers where annual festivals and special events such as weddings could be celebrated, where cultural traditions such as Indian dance and musical concerts could be performed, and where youth education programs could take place. Most temples were constructed with rooms designed for such activities, often including a classroom and library. Many parents who immigrated to America and raised their children with these comics reported that they donated them to their local Hindu temple after the children grew up; and Hindus who grew up in America often reported that they read these comics with their Indian-heritage friends at the temple library or in youth education classes. One young man who grew up in the Bay Area in California, for instance, reported that he loved the comics because *ACK* "tells stories about Hindu culture and it teaches about good qualities that one should have. And it doesn't have stories only about one god, but many gods." When asked where he read these comics, he reported that he "read so many of them at the library of my local temple, the Shiva-Vishnu Temple of Livermore, California."

The Shiva-Vishnu Temple was incorporated as a Hindu community and cultural center in 1977, and it has an active youth and education department with regular class offerings for both children and adults, as well as a learning center that contains among other items an "almost full set of *Amar Chitra Katha* books for the children—all bound in sets of 3 to 5."[2] The Shiva-Vishnu Temple has a dual worship focus: both the gods Shiva and Vishnu are enshrined within the temple, along with their respective entourages, including Vishnu's wife, the goddess Lakshmi, and Shiva's wife, the goddess Parvati. With its dual focus and sanctums to multiple deities, this temple stands apart from traditional temples in India, which are typically dedicated to either Shiva or Vishnu, but not both. Historically in India these gods have more often acted as sectarian rivals than as interfaith brothers, but outside of India, in places where Hindus are but a small minority, Hindus from various regional, linguistic, and sectarian backgrounds have often joined together to create a sacred space where Shaiva, Vaishnava, and Shakta gods all have representation in an effort to unify the Hindu community and make all members feel welcome.[3] Thus this reader's comment that he likes the *ACK* comics precisely because they feature the stories of multiple Hindu gods has important theological significance, for it points to one way that Hinduism is changing in the diaspora: the now prevalent doctrine that "Truth is One, paths are many." In the effort to unify the many Hindu traditions into one Hinduism, and also to counter charges of idolatry in countries where image worship is often regarded with suspicion, Hindus now regularly proclaim in temple bulletins and philosophical sermons that in Hinduism there are many images or "idols" of gods, but all are symbols of the One True God (Eck 2002, 86; Narayanan 1992, 165). Therefore, Shaivas, Vaishnavas, and Shaktas should learn to recognize one another as co-religionists who are united in their devotion to God. Throughout the transnational Hindu community, the *ACK* series helps to unite Hindus across the various sectarian divides—the many paths—by featuring issues that explain the mythology of Rama, Krishna, Shiva, Durga, and other Hindu deities.

Commenting on the predominant position of *Amar Chitra Katha* comic books and the "controlled diet" of simplified creeds such as "Truth is One, paths are many" in temple Hinduism as it is practiced in America, Vasudha Narayanan sounds a cautionary note:

> The influence of these articles in the [temple] bulletins should not be underestimated; unlike a person in India, where newspapers and regular television programming carry glimpses of varied rituals and synopses of religious discourses, these articles may be the only regular "religious education" the readers of the bulletin get. By appearing in this bulletin, the articles also

> seem authoritative. Thus we may have an entire generation of young Hindus growing up in this country, educated on the myths recounted by *Amar Chitra Katha*—where again, *one* story line is presented and is ratified as "true" unlike the oral tradition, which may present alternative versions of a story—and on symbolic meanings of temples, deities, and rituals. The effects of this controlled diet will have to be judged in future years. (1992, 168–69)

Indeed, *ACK* comics often attain an even greater significance in the religious lives of their transnational readers than in the religious lives of their readers in India, where these comic books are just one source among many for learning about Hindu beliefs and practices. I first realized how important *ACK* was in the American diaspora when I was a teaching assistant at the University of Texas at Austin, where many students of Indian heritage enrolled in the undergraduate courses on South Asian religion and culture. Frequently, these comics were the primary means by which these students had learned Hindu mythology. Thus in one course on the Indian epics, as we read the ending of an English translation of the Sanskrit *Rāmāyaṇa* epic by Valmiki, in which Rama banishes his pregnant wife, Sita, to the forest based on unfounded rumors of her infidelity, one student protested that this ending was wrong, exclaiming vociferously that the epic ends when Rama and Sita return victoriously to their kingdom and are crowned king and queen. As I explained that that was the end of the sixth book of the epic, but there was also a seventh book in which Sita is banished and raises her twin sons alone in exile at Valmiki's forest hermitage, the student grew quiet and withdrew from the conversation in contemplation. Later that week, he brought in his *Valmiki's Ramayana* (bumper issue no. 10001, 1992) and showed me its ending (plate 8): a final full-page panel featuring Rama and Sita being crowned king and queen. Although I tried to use this as a "teaching moment" to instruct my student about the many different renditions of the Indian epics that have been composed over the centuries, in the end this student taught me about the significance of these comic books. For him, clearly, the *ACK* version of the *Rāmāyaṇa* epic featuring Rama as a superhero who encounters his foes, defeats them in battle, and then rules Ayodhya happily ever after was the only version of the epic that mattered: it was the "true" version of Valmiki's *Rāmāyaṇa*.

A Closed Canon of Indian Heroes?

In 1991, when Anant Pai and the other *ACK* producers decided to stop creating new issues and focus only on reprinting bestsellers, a curious thing happened. Despite the well-known hardships that the entire print industry in India was encountering at this time and the obvious financial reasoning behind this decision, a persistent rumor arose that the creators had to stop making these comic books because there were no more Indian heroes left. When asked if there were other figures that they felt should be featured in

the comic book series, reader after reader explained that there weren't any figures left to include. "All of the major characters have already been done," said one reader in Bombay. "That is why they stopped making new issues." Another asked, "Who else could they feature? It has all been done—the great saints, the kings, the freedom fighters, all the heroes of India!" While a few readers did wish for new issues on contemporary political leaders and Hindu swamis—and a few requested an *ACK* comic version of *Lord of the Rings*—the general consensus among the readers I interviewed was that the comic book series had completely represented all of India's immortal heroes, mythological and historical. Other readers replied: "I'd be surprised if they left any facet of Indian mythology, history untouched"; "*ACK* has done all the stories from all over India, and a couple folk tales from other countries as well"; "*Amar Chitra Katha* adequately represents all of India as we get to know about the folk tales, saints, and freedom fighters from the different parts of India"; and "There are so many worshippable demigods and gods, but personally I know *Amar Chitra Katha* has virtually exhausted all of them." For these readers, the national canon of gods, kings, and other heroes was complete—no other regional Hindu gods and goddesses, no other religious figures from India's other religious traditions, no other men and women from any historical period need be added.

The case studies of the mythological and historical issues presented in the preceding chapters have shown that the *Amar Chitra Katha* comic book series is a form of public culture wherein ideologies of religion and national identity are actively created and re-created amid ongoing debate. We have seen how the artists, authors, and editors involved in the creative process have debated several significant questions during the making of these Indian comic books: What textual and visual resources are considered authentically Indian? What is the place of science and faith in postcolonial India? Which Hindu gods and goddesses are central to Hinduism? Who is the ideal Indian woman? What roles do Muslims and other non-Hindus play in Indian history and society? And who should be remembered as heroes of the struggle for India's independence? But as Christopher Pinney warns, we must also pay attention to the limits of such debates, for in public culture there is also "ample evidence of erasure, of the elevation of particular dominant norms, alongside an ongoing debate about the nature of personal, community, and national identity" (2001, 9). These case studies have also shown the limits of these debates. For instance, throughout the making and remaking of the first issue, *Krishna* (no. 11, 1969), and the debates over the propriety of depicting miracles, no one challenged the assumption that all Indian children needed to learn Krishna's story. And despite the new emphasis on authenticity during the production of *Tales of Durga* (no. 176, 1978), everyone agreed to the need to sanitize goddess Kali to make her more appealing. These issues demonstrate not only the

centrality of Hinduism to this Indian comic book series but also that it is a modern, middle-class, upper-caste, predominantly Vaishnava strand of Hinduism. In the 1970s, when debates arose about the depiction of women and Muslims that resulted in an alternative feminine ideal and in the portrayal of some Muslim emperors as heroes, an emphasis was nonetheless maintained on the heroines' ultimate self-sacrifice and on the evils of Muslim orthodoxy. During the making of *Shivaji* (no. 23, 1971), we saw that care was taken to portray him as a warrior-king that both Brahmins and non-Brahmins could look up to. Yet artists, authors, and editors agreed to the depiction of him as a manly defender of Maharashtra and the larger Hindu nation. The portrayal of Gandhi in various comics in conjunction with references to the Jallianwala Bagh massacre likewise demonstrates the preference for a more militant form of nationalism, as well as regional and caste influences, in the presentation of this modern Indian icon. Overall, these case studies demonstrate that hegemonic conceptions of Hinduism and national Indian identity do not exist passively but are actively created amid ongoing debate.

And yet this debate is in many ways limited to the production process. Whereas readers do actively participate in these debates about religion and nation by deciding which comic books to buy and which to bypass and by writing letters to the comic book producers, one factor that significantly hampers the possibility of ongoing discussion about what it means to be Hindu and Indian is the context in which the *ACK* comics are consumed by the majority of their readers. In India, they are now used in urban English-medium schools as an alternative to textbooks. As one principal in Bombay stated, "Up through the ninth standard we teach for life; in the tenth standard we teach for examinations." She went on to explain that in preparing students for this transition, the *Amar Chitra Katha* comic books are a useful tool:

> In fact, we have made the *Freedom Struggle* [bumper issue no. 10, 1997] comic book compulsory reading for the ninth standard. In the tenth standard they have to do a paper on the Freedom Struggle, so this gives them some background, some ability to visualize the important figures ahead of time. And it is not as heavy as the textbooks they will have to read in tenth standard for their exams and their papers. And we give *Amar Chitra Kathas* out as awards to our students at various functions.

Other principals of English-medium schools in Bombay and elsewhere confirmed that they too regularly use these comic books as a part of their curriculum and stock both the historical and the mythological issues in their libraries. In discussing the function of South Asian education systems, Krishna Kumar writes that educating children is not only about teaching them a love of reading or math or science. It is also about transforming them into good national subjects:

> [S]ystems of education are oriented towards cultivating the characteristics of loyal citizens in children, in preference to the development of their intellectual or contemplative capacities. As far as teaching about the past is concerned, schools in different systems perform the job of socializing the young into an approved national past . . . the school uses the officially approved knowledge of the nation's past to inspire and prepare children for fulfilling the roles expected of them as obedient citizens. (2001, 20–21)

When educators present the *ACK* comic books to children as an authentic source of information about India that they should memorize, then the possibility for greater debate about and alternative visions of what it means to be Indian is largely foreclosed. Likewise, in the diaspora where the *ACK* comic books are used in youth education classes and stocked in libraries at Hindu temples, and are again presented to children as an authentic source of information about India and Hinduism, the possibility for greater debate about what it means to be Indian and Hindu is again largely foreclosed.

In the past several years, however, a few who grew up on a steady diet of *Amar Chitra Katha* comics in India and around the globe have begun to rethink the vision of Indianness that is presented in this series and that they so identified with as children. In New Delhi, Rukmini Sekhar has started a new Indian comic book series called *Vivalok Comics*. Sekhar acknowledged her indebtedness to *ACK*, which she fondly recalled reading as a child, but stated that in her comics she and her co-producers try to "draw out the undercurrents and subtleties of mythology, to use comic books for rigorous inquiry." For instance, in their *Godavari Tales* issue (not numbered, 2003), a very different version of the *Rāmāyaṇa* epic is presented in the short story entitled "Sita Banished." Whereas the *Rama* and *Valmiki's Ramayana* comics by *ACK* deploy the strategy of narrative closure to end with a happily-ever-after scenario depicting Rama and Sita being crowned king and queen of Ayodhya, "Sita Banished" begins where these comic books end and focuses on the final book of the epic, a part of the epic that has been central to many women's retellings of this epic for centuries, in which Rama banishes Sita.[4] It ends with a final panel in which Sita is shown wandering alone in the forest (figure 38), while the narrative text concludes, "Since he was king, he banished Sita to the forest. That too when she was carrying her first child! So . . . what do you make of Rama's decision?" (41). This version of the *Rāmāyaṇa* dwells on the moral ambiguities of the epic, calling into question not only the justness of Rama's behavior toward Sita but also the dominant version of the epic that presents Rama as a flawless god-king, an ever-victorious superhero.

In the United States, New York–based artist Chitra Ganesh has created her own comic book, *Tales of Amnesia* (2002), as well as a number of large single-panel prints by using digital manipulation, collage, and other techniques to alter the narratives of *Amar Chitra Katha* comic books and

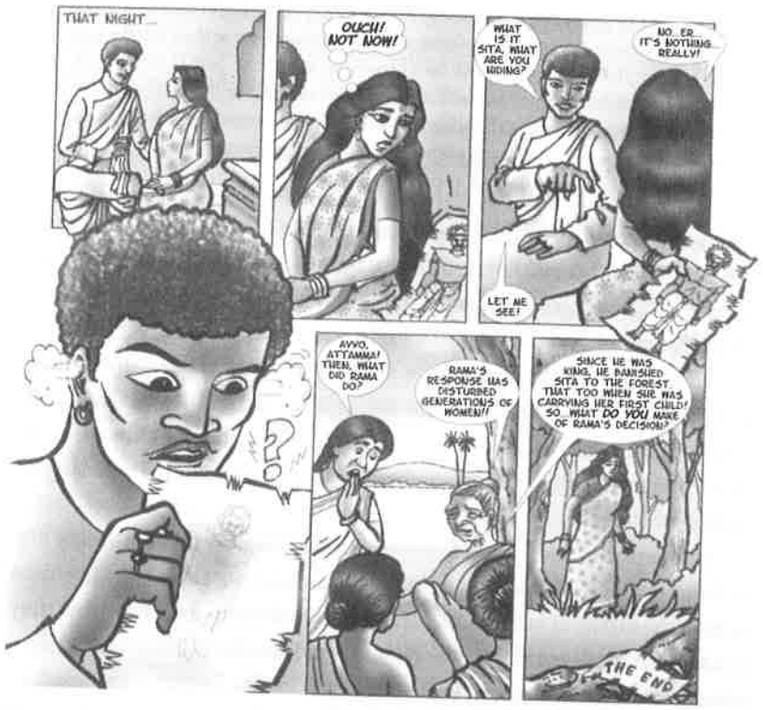

Figure 38. *Godavari Tales*, not numbered (New Delhi: Viveka Foundation, 2003), 41. From the *Vivalok Comics* series, with the permission of the publisher Viveka Foundation, New Delhi, India.

thereby infuse them with new meaning. In this work, Ganesh questions the definition of Indianness presented in *ACK* by raising queer issues and feminist critiques and by making more subtle commentaries upon life in the Indian diaspora. In her own words, she engages "familiar narrative and pictorial conventions to draw the viewer into a tale of disintegration and discomfort." For the cover of *Tales of Amnesia*, she has adapted the splash page from the *Hanuman* (no. 19, 1971) *ACK* issue, transforming the mythological monkey-god into a half-monkey, half-human *junglee* (wild or barbaric) girl who defies social norms. In these pages she depicts lesbian sexuality, draws connections between the plight of women in premodern India and Indian women in the diaspora, and pairs fractured bodies with jarring text segments. When asked what led her to *Amar Chitra Katha* and prompted her to consider using these comics in her own artwork, Ganesh replied:

> I read these comics as a kid, and it was in large part the way I learned about Indian myth, history, and religion. A few years ago, my girlfriend sent me a package when I was away at a residency with a few of these books. From that point on, this work grew out of revisiting and dissecting stories of the *Amar Chitra Katha*, a popular religious comic used to disseminate "authentic" Indian culture to the subcontinent and diaspora. I interrupt the original tales by inserting dissonant dialogue into stories, and fracturing the coherence of bodies that inhabit them. Bodies split open, double, and otherwise transform as history and fantasy merge. In the process, I want to unsettle traditional narrative structures and activate the comic's potential as a subversive form.

Overall, however, the vast majority of the readers of *Amar Chitra Katha* cherish this comic book series for its heroic presentation of India's historical and mythological leaders. For these readers, Rama remains the archetypal Indian superhero (plate 8): seated magnificently on his throne, he is immortalized as the ever-victorious god-king who defeated the demon-king Ravana, rescued his lovely and long-suffering wife, Sita, and returned to Ayodhya to begin his ideal reign. In addition to Hindu deities like Rama and Krishna, the series includes issues on celebrated Hindu warrior-kings such as Shivaji and Rana Pratap and colonial era freedom fighters such as Bhagat Singh and Subhas Chandra Bose. All of these figures are transformed into heroes by adhering to the successful *ACK* formula: They encounter their foes, be they mythological demons or medieval Muslim kings or colonial British officers, engage them in fierce battles, and either emerge victorious or die bravely in the process. For the majority of the readers of *ACK*, this Indian comic book series presents a national canon of gods, kings, and other heroes that they regard as both authentic and complete.

As a form of public culture that has reached into the everyday lives of millions of middle-class Indian children over the past four decades, *Amar Chitra Katha* has had a substantial impact on their concepts of Hinduism and Indianness. But the influence of *ACK* extends even beyond its significant reading audience. These Indian comic books draw on a long tradition of Indian visual and literary culture, and they have been especially influenced by the Indian nationalist period in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries when popular texts and images (including paintings, god posters, and bazaar art) were employed in the struggle for independence from British colonial rule. If, as Arjun Appadurai and Carol Breckenridge have argued, each new media technology in South Asia "has distinctive capabilities and functions, and each interacts in a different way with older modes of organizing and disseminating information" (1995, 7), then it is also important to acknowledge the ways in which newer media in India in turn draw on comic books. The production of *ACK* comic books began in 1967, before satellite television had become entrenched in urban India, and these comic books have had a direct, though little-recognized, influence on this medium in India. Sales of the comic books boomed from the 1970s to the mid-1980s. But in the mid-1980s and early 1990s, television suddenly became available throughout urban India as hundreds of transmitters were erected (Mankekar 1999, 5). In the mid-1980s, televised entertainment serials were introduced on Doordarshan, the state-run network, and the most successful one of this time was Ramanand Sagar's *Ramayan*, which aired from January 1987 until July 1988 and captured an estimated daily viewership of 40 to 60 million, with the most popular episodes being

viewed by 80 to 100 million people (Lutgendorf 1995, 223). *Amar Chitra Katha* and Doordarshan were competing for the same audience, and Doordarshan appeared to be winning. Throughout the late 1980s *ACK* sales slid, until the producers finally stopped making new issues in 1991.

But focusing only on the competition between these two media for India's middle-class audience causes us to overlook the interconnections between these media. Philip Lutgendorf has commented on the "homogenization" he sees between the comic books and the *Ramayan* TV series, noting that "visually speaking, the characters and settings of the Sagar serial look much like those of the *Amar Chitra Katha* comic books" (1995, 246). This is particularly true in the final hourlong episode (no. 78), which aired on July 31, 1988, and ended the series with Rama's coronation in a way that seems directly indebted to the comic book: seated magnificently on his throne with Sita at his side, Rama is immortalized as the ever-victorious god-king and ideal ruler. *ACK* author Yagya Sharma had an explanation for this visual and narrative homogenization that occurs in *Ramayan* and also B. R. Chopra's TV series *Mahabharat,* which aired from September 1988 until July 1990:

> I have a story to tell you about that. You see, when the *Mahabharat* TV serial was being made—this was over ten years ago—I had a friend who was a cameraman on the set. And he told me that they often brought the *ACK Mahabharata* series onto the set and used it as reference material—for the dress, the buildings, and also for the episodes, the content. It is Kamala Chandrakant who deserves the credit for this. She was thorough and very, very careful with regards to authenticity. For every event that occurs in the *ACK Mahabharata*—the 42-volume set!—there is an actual *sloka* [verse] on that event in Sanskrit in the *Mahabharat* epic.

Television producers have repeatedly turned to the *Amar Chitra Katha* series as reference material for costume design, set production, and subject matter. When making the live-action serial based on the *Amar Chitra Katha* comic books that aired on UTV in 1998, producer Zarina Mehta stated that the idea seemed plausible to her because the comic books are quite cinematic already, particularly in the way that they "alternate action with a lot of drama and emotion," which makes their adaptation to the television medium a relatively simple process. Mehta was inspired to undertake this project because she credits these comic books with helping her as a Parsi to learn Indian mythology, and she wanted to bring that Indian heritage to a new generation:

> The comics taught me a lot. I read them all when I was younger, and they inspired me to learn more about these things. In fact, I still have all of them somewhere around here. The comics were quite popular with many Indian children when I was growing up, Hindus and also non-Hindus, like me. They are the reason that we know India's mythology, the reason we can visualize it and remember it. So we thought a TV serial based on these comics could help bring India's history and mythology to a new generation. And I really enjoyed producing the show. It was great fun.

During the making of this series, the Sagars, who produced *Ramayan,* and the Chopras, who produced *Mahabharat,* each co-produced some of the *ACK* TV episodes, furthering the homogenization between these two media in their respective visions of who India's heroes are, what they look like, and how their stories should be told.

Like these television serials, dozens of Indian films have also been produced in the past quarter century featuring the same Indian heroes that were canonized in *ACK* and demonstrate the marked influence of these comic books in the ways that these heroes are envisioned and their stories are told in the filmic medium. Creators of new animated cartoons and children's internet productions in India are also now turning to *ACK* for inspiration. Thus not only have *Amar Chitra Katha* comic books been instrumental in establishing a national canon of heroes that defines what it means to be Hindu and Indian for millions of middle-class readers in India and throughout the transnational Indian diaspora. These comics have also been instrumental in disseminating that definition of Hinduism and Indianness through other popular Indian media.